

CHAPTER EIGHT
THE ART AND SCIENCE OF FORMING A PUBLIC

John Dewey thought Lippmann surrendered "the case for the press too readily" ("Review of Public Opinion by Walter Lippmann" 288) Why hand over the responsibility for knowing about social problems to bureaucrats in government and industry when the ability of the press to interest people in the issues of the day had yet to be tested? Rather than stressing the limits on the citizen's knowledge--Lippmann's theme--Dewey argued that such limits could not yet be known, for propaganda and other distractions were short-circuiting the process by which a public could be enlightened. "Until secrecy, prejudice, bias, misrepresentation, and propaganda as well as sheer ignorance are replaced by inquiry and publicity, we have no way of telling how apt for judgment of social policies the existing intelligence of the masses may be," wrote Dewey in The Public and its Problems, published in 1927 partly as a response to Lippmann (209).

Instead of exposing the myth of an informed public, Dewey was interested in how such a public might come to be. He recognized as valid almost all of what Lippmann had said

in Public Opinion, calling it in a review "perhaps the most effective indictment of democracy as currently conceived ever penned" (286). But the defects Lippmann saw in public opinion were not inherent in human nature or in the nature of democracy, Dewey argued. They were partly the result of the way we have thought about the public and the use to which the agencies of public communication had been put. There was a chance, he thought, that the very powers now preventing an informed public from coming into existence could be employed in a different fashion. Mass communication offered the hope of distributing intelligence on a scale equal to the challenges a democratic public faced. But if such a dream were to be realized, it would involve much more than the presentation of information in the newspapers. Like Lippmann, Dewey did not equate information publicly available with an informed public. To him the public was never something one could assume was "out there." The public was a condition democracy had to struggle to achieve. With this view he transcended the assumptions of the professional journalist and offered a new perspective on press and public, which, like Lippmann's, has yet to be assimilated into theory or practice.

Origins of the democratic public

Dewey agreed with Lippmann that World War I was a good starting point for discussing the problem of the public. The scope of the Great War showed that a new scale had entered world relations. Everything was now connected to everything else through technology, finance and the new tools of communication. It was possible to declare a nation neutral, but not to actually remain uninvolved. The effects of the war extended through a complex of causes to every nation and region on earth, regardless of its political affiliation. So there was a sense in which the world had become more united. For Dewey the problem was the basis of this new unity. It was not conscious and rational but hidden and unplanned. Unseen forces created by modern industrialism compelled states to interact, but the war was proof that they had not understood how to recognize and manage this new scale of interdependence.

The connection and ties which transferred energies set in motion in one spot to all parts of the earth were not tangible and visible; they do not stand out as do politically bounded states. But the war is there to show that they are as real, and to prove that they are not organized and regulated. It suggests that existing political and legal forms and arrangements are incompetent to deal with the situation. (The Public and its Problems 128)

What was true at the level of world politics was true for the nation, as well. Technology and the scale of modern capitalism created a more interdependent society in which no

part was isolated from any other. But this new level of interdependence had yet to be recognized and assimilated into forms of thought. An outdated individualism was upheld at just the moment when the individual--whether it be a person, a village, a corporation or a nation--could no longer be considered apart from the whole.¹ The result was a functional gap between the causes of social change and the means available to recognize and control it.

Persons are joined together not because they have voluntarily chosen to be united in these forms, but because vast currents are running which bring men together. Green and red lines, marking out political boundaries, are on the maps and affect legislation and jurisdiction of the courts, but railways, mails, and telegraph wires disregard them. (107)

This was the perspective from which Dewey developed his philosophy of press and public: on the one hand, association as a social fact caused by advances in technology and industry; on the other, association as an achievement of conscious, thinking people. The gap between one form of association and the other was the area he sought to explore. "Symbols control sentiment and thought," he wrote, "and the new age has no symbols consonant with its activities" (142). How this disjunction between ideas and conditions bore upon the problem of a democratic public was the focus of The Public and its Problems.

Dewey did not equate the public with "the people" or the voters; nor did he assume that the public was created by fiat with the adoption of the Constitution. He was more

interested in the social conditions which caused a public to come about. These could be investigated, he thought, by counterposing the terms "public" and "private." A public begins, Dewey said, when private actions begin to affect people other than the actors themselves. (This line of demarcation is expressed banally in the popular phrase from the 1960s, "Do your own thing as long as it doesn't hurt anyone else.") As soon as private actions begin to intrude on "someone else," the territory with which a public is concerned comes into being. This territory--an area of indirect consequences in which private actions bear upon many lives--is the first meaning of the term "public" (15-16). A public actually begins to exist as a political unit when the community becomes aware of these indirect consequences and organizes itself to control them in the common good. The name given to that organization and its officials is the state (67-9). So there are two meanings to the term "public" in Dewey's conception. One is the territory private actions enter when they begin to affect the common interests. The other is the body of citizens who perceive the scope and significance of that territory and have organized themselves to control what happens within it. Without the ability to identify the problems in which it has a legitimate interest, the public remains "inchoate," unconstituted, a fact that has failed to come to light. There could be public institutions and public officials, a

whole state apparatus and yet no "public" in Dewey's sense of the term, no body of citizens who understand those problems that are truly public.

Too much public

The argument in The Public and its Problems is that the scale of modern society greatly increases the territory in which the public has a legitimate and necessary interest. It does so because it involves every local unit and every individual in a web of interrelationships, where the outcome of action in one sphere inevitably affects action in another. The railroad, the telegraph, the steam engine and the new scale of corporate capitalism had put a decisive end to the self-contained community. Much of what happened in the modern citizen's daily life was now an indirect result of this new complexity, Dewey observed. But the causes of social change are so remote in origin that they are "felt rather than perceived; they are suffered, but they cannot be said to be known" (131). In essence, there was "too much public," meaning a realm of public problems too large and dense to understand, and at the same time, "too many publics," groups whose attention was fixed narrowly on matters of local or private interest (137). The challenge, then, was one

of discovering the means by which a scattered, mobile and manifold public may so recognize itself as to define and express its interests. (146)

The agencies of mass communication offered the best hope that this problem could be solved in democracy's favor. Dewey shared with Charles Cooley and other progressive thinkers the faith that modern means of communication could extend the territory over which humans could exert conscious, rational and democratic control. The fact that it was possible to communicate on the grandest possible scale meant, to them, that ideas could now be distributed on the grandest possible scale, making it feasible for everyone to participate in the rational direction of society.² The speed and scale of modern technology meant that the public had to know more, and that knowing it would be more difficult. But the same technology also provided the means to know, and these means reached everyone in the society. This was the promise of modern communication. But the promise had remained only a theoretic possibility, Dewey conceded. Technology had been "deflected" to private ends (Individualism Old and New 65). Propaganda and publicity were creating only the most superficial sort of agreement. Public sentiment careened from crisis to crisis, incident to incident. "We think and feel alike--but only for a month or a season" (86-7). It was misleading to call opinions based on ignorance or prejudice "public opinions" simply because they came from ordinary people, Dewey said. For in truth the public had not yet been brought into existence.

Unless there are methods for detecting the energies at work and tracing them through an intricate network of interactions to their consequences, what passes for public opinion will be "opinion" only in its derogatory sense rather than truly public, no matter how widespread the opinion is.... Opinion casually formed and formed under the direction of those who have something at stake in having a lie believed can be public opinion only in name. Calling it by this name, acceptance of the name as a kind of warrant, magnifies its capacity to lead action astray. (The Public and its Problems 177-8)

There was no public, Dewey thought, because there was no method for bringing about a general understanding of social causes that would allow people to trace problems back to their sources. Dewey agreed with Lippmann that news was not providing this understanding. The physical means for collecting and distributing information had "far outrun the intellectual phase" of the journalism problem, Dewey wrote (179). This other phase involved the fashioning of news into a coherent picture of a complex society at work. Without such coherence, news could never inform people. "Only continuous inquiry, continuous in the sense of being connected as well as persistent, can provide the material of enduring opinion about public matters," he argued (178). The failure of the news to provide a structure for understanding recent events is one explanation for sensationalism. Sensationalism is what "the new" degenerates into when there is no way of placing recent events in context and perceiving causes (180).

Science and the democratic citizen

Like Lippmann, Dewey thought that social science would have to pick up where the news was faltering-- specifically, at the point where journalism failed to place events in relation to one another. But where Lippmann would assign this task to expert bureaus of research, Dewey insisted that the results of social inquiry had to be more fully communicated to citizens. Both believed in social science as a treatment for the problems confronting democracy. But Lippmann emphasized the science and Dewey the social. Science to Dewey offered the ideal method by which a society could operate democratically. The problem at present, he wrote, is that "we use scientific method in directing physical but not human energies." The scientific community, based on public review of results and general agreement on what is known to be true, could be a model for the wider human community. "Suppose," said Dewey, "that what now happens in limited circles were extended and generalized?" (Individualism Old and New 154-5) As David W. Marcell observes, Dewey was confident that "the method of experimental science and the processes of democracy were congenial, even parallel." Therefore democracy's best hope was science. "Science had to be democratized and democracy made more scientific before true progress could be assured.

Thus the real scientific revolution was yet to come," Marcell writes (244).

Part of that revolution involved the press, which was obviously the best hope for democratizing scientific inquiry. Dewey went so far as to say that a "genuine social science" would present itself as an advanced form of journalism (The Public and its Problems 180). In 1892 he had even joined in an effort to start a newspaper devoted to that principle. The journal was to be called "Thought News," and the idea was to create a form of journalism which overcame the superficiality and disjointedness which seemed to be inherent in the news. "Thought News" would use the insights of philosophy and sociology to reveal structure and function and pattern, not as abstract concepts but as forces at work in current events. And it would aim for an audience, not of academics but of ordinary citizens. Take the organicist model of society which Dewey, Cooley and others inherited from Herbert Spencer. As Dewey wrote in explaining the "Thought News" project,

When it can be seen, for example, that Walt Whitman's poetry, the development of short stories at present, the centralizing tendency in the railroads and the introduction of business methods into charity organizations are all parts of the organic social movement, then the philosophical ideas about organism begin to look like something definite. (qtd. in Matthews 22)

Dewey was excited by the project because it seemed like a way to make real his conviction that thought should never

be cut off from action, that idealism must find its expression in the world of practical problems. To show "the idea in motion," to sort out "typical facts" from mere happenings, to get at the laws underlying actual events--these were to be the aims of "Thought News." But the paper never appeared. Dewey, at the time a professor at Michigan, drew a good deal of criticism from the local press and backed out of the project. Later he recalled that the idea was a sound one, but that he and his colleagues had not the means nor the maturity to carry it out.³

The "Thought News" project is an interesting example of Dewey's faith, not only in the ability of science to explain the social world but also in the potential interest ordinary people might take in the process of scientific inquiry. To him it was not a matter of popularizing science, but of creating a scientific spirit in the population. He never doubted that the ordinary person was capable of the scientific attitude. No arguments about the "limits of attention" or the ignorance of the masses impressed him. There was no natural or inevitable limit on what most people could know of the world; the only limit that did exist, the inability to reach everyone quickly and cheaply, had been overcome by modern communication. So why not a nation of educated citizens discoursing in the spirit of science? As Henry J. Perkinson observed in discussing Dewey's program for the schools,

The progressives' educational program, Dewey's version of it, envisions a society wherein all citizens are nothing less than scientists, working together and jointly solving their common problems. (194)

This was the real promise of democracy: not the right to vote or to compete in the marketplace, but the right to make sense of the world using the best methods available for knowing about it-- the tools of science. And the press was the logical defender of that right. With this vision Dewey placed himself with those mid-nineteenth century dreamers who thought that the newspaper would usher in a new world harmony by making possible a "universal town meeting." But unlike the earlier utopians of the newspaper he did not believe that information alone would be enough to create an informed citizenry. To place events in relation to one another, to penetrate surfaces and see structures at work, to trace occurrences back toward their causes-- these were as necessary as information.

Pleasure and the art of arresting attention

But where would the demand from such in-depth reporting come from? From the same people who demand murder stories and ball scores and advice to lovers. Thirty years after the "Thought News" experiment, Dewey argued in his review of Public Opinion that "a competent treatment of the news of the day," one based on scientific research and organized

intelligence, could be "more sensational" than the sensationalist press.

To see underlying forces moving through events seemingly casual and disjointed will give a thrill which no report confined to the superficial and detached incident can give. (288)

News offering the thrill of real discovery might conceivably attract the artistic talent needed to make the scientific report interesting. Dewey agreed with Lippmann that news and truth had parted ways, one concerned solely with events, the other with the conditions causing them. The solution, however, was not to hand over the pursuit of truth to experts, as Lippmann seemed to say, but to move news closer to truth by simultaneously improving its intellectual content and its aesthetic form. A "union of social science, access to facts, and the art of literary presentation" was "the only genuine solution to the problem of an intelligent direction of social life," Dewey wrote (288). The problem of improving the press and informing the public must be attacked from two angles: science and art. Only the two in tandem could redeem the promise of modern communication. In The Public and its Problems Dewey set out his vision of how "an organized, articulate Public" might come into being:

The highest and most difficult kind of inquiry and a subtle, delicate, vivid and responsive art of communication must take possession of the physical machinery of transmission and circulation and breathe life into it. When the machine age has thus perfected its machinery it will be a means of life and not its despotic master. Democracy will come

into its own, for democracy is a name for a life of free and enriching communion. It had its seer in Walt Whitman. It will have its consummation when free social inquiry is indissolubly wedded to the art of full and moving communication. (184)

Dewey was under no illusions about why people read newspapers, if indeed they do. They read because an item interests them, because there are pleasures and thrills to be found in the news. Lippmann was inclined to see the role of pleasure and desire as inherently limiting. The desire to be entertained meant that the average citizen could know very little about the world, since he obviously had no "appetite for uninteresting truths" (Public Opinion 228). Lippmann's view went along with a long-standing belief that the higher arts and a higher understanding of the world were difficult--perhaps even boring--in any event not immediately pleasurable. As Michael Schudson observes, the division between news as "human interest" and as "information" has often taken on a moral tone. "People control themselves to read of politics in fine print," he writes. "They let themselves go to read of murders or to look at drawings of celebrities. Information is a genre of self-denial, the story one of self-indulgence" (Discovering the News 119). Dewey would not accept this opposition. Thinking and inquiry are pleasures themselves, he argued. Why not make them available to everyone? (Individualism Old and New 161). This was the point at which art must enter journalism, he argued. Art must be freed from purely

commercial motives, on the one hand, and purely academic audiences, on the other, to become the means by which a democracy took an interest in itself. The question was not how to get people to "control themselves" so that they could read the inherently uninteresting but important news. It was to discover the forms of presentation which would make the important news interesting and turn the work of citizenship into a kind of play.⁴ Creating an informed public, Dewey wrote,

is an artistic as well as an intellectual problem, for it supposes not only a scientific organization for discovering, recording and interpreting all conduct having a public bearing, but also methods which make presentation of the results of inquiry arresting and weighty. I do not suppose that most persons buy sugar because of belief in its nutritive value; they buy from habit and to please the palate. And so it must be with the buying of the facts which would prepare various publics in particular and the wider public in general to see private activities in their public bearings and to deal with them on the basis of the public interest. ("Practical Democracy" 54)

The communicators most concerned about "the art of presentation" were the advertisers and propagandists, the experts in appealing to emotions and impulses. They were doing for private interests what journalism ought to be doing for the public domain. "Any separation between the two sides of the problem is artificial," Dewey wrote (The Public and its Problems 181). Propaganda and journalism were both concerned with interesting large numbers of people in their message. Whereas one "deflected" its discoveries

to the pursuit of private gain, the other ought to be making the same discoveries and putting them to public ends. The job of the press, in Dewey's conception, is to interest the public in the public interest. For again, there is no public until there is a body of citizens made aware of those problems that affect the common good. There were many other communicators attempting to interest the public for other than public reasons. The press was therefore engaged in a battle which could not be won by simply improving the accuracy, depth or breadth of the news. The entire communication environment was journalism's domain. The press had to keep one eye on worldly events and the other on the world of symbols and representations, the aesthetic dimension of the mass media, in which there were discoveries and events, trends and reversals.⁵

"All the News That's Fit to Print" could not serve as a motto for the press in Dewey's conception. For it was not the printing of news, but its being read and understood and worked into political behavior that counted. Journalists are communicators, not transmitters. Their job is not to send messages, even very good and complete ones, but, working against their adversaries in the private domain, to create competence among the great mass of citizens and thereby allow a public to exist. "Dissemination is something other than scattering at large," Dewey wrote. "Seeds are sown, not by virtue of being thrown out at

random, but by being so distributed as to take root and have a chance of growth" (177). Advertisers did not consider it their job to simply print ads; they were out to affect behavior. Propagandists were not content to simply present their appeals; they wanted to change minds or move people to action. Any success these other communicators had was a small defeat for journalism, for it meant that common symbols, each a clue to the national life of feeling, were being deflected to private ends (168-9). Therefore it was not enough to print news. The goal of journalism was to communicate in a public way about public problems, and to succeed against those using the public channels for more limited goals. Success could be measured not by reference to the content of the newspaper or the power of the journalism profession, but by the degree to which a public actually emerged. And a public could only emerge by demonstrating an understanding of common problems and organizing itself to control them.

Politics without polity

So goes our summary of Dewey's vision of press and public. Let us now interpret his ideas in light of the professional attitude in journalism. It is possible to call Dewey a utopian on the subject of the press. After all, the notion that sociology could be made "thrilling" to mass audiences might strike even the most faithful democratic as

a little bizzare. But from a different angle Dewey can be seen as the hard headed realist, especially when it came to the question of "informing the public." He would have thought it utopian for the press, or anyone else, to assume that the public was "out there." It was misleading to speak of the "public" and "public opinion" as if these things existed, he argued.

For public opinion is judgment which is formed and entertained by those who constitute the public and is about public affairs. Each of these two phases imposes for its realization conditions hard to meet. (emphasis added; 177)

It stands to reason that "conditions hard to meet" in Dewey's time are certainly more difficult today. Not only is there "more public" than ever, meaning more problems and issues bearing on the common good, but there is now a new range of powerful distractions available to mass audiences through television. TV worsens every defect Lippmann and Dewey saw in public opinion, making it less likely than ever that a public worthy of its name could be brought into existence. Market research and image consulting have given new power to the stereotype, which can now be distributed with something akin to scientific precision. The principle behind the USA Today--to create a newspaper totally tuned to reader demand--signals a retreat from the challenge Dewey issued. While the paper has made brilliant discoveries in what Dewey called "the art of presentation" it has not put them in the service of a more subtle understanding of social

reality, but instead reduced reality to the common level of understanding. That is why sports, weather, entertainment and trivia comprise most of "the world" for the USA Today. In consciously trying to compete with television, the Gannett Company has ended up expanding TV's influence. There is now a form of print journalism which, as the paper's ads say, is "quick instead of slow, interesting instead of dull, visual instead of verbal." Dewey's hope was that that a public-minded press could begin to compete with the art of arresting attention as it was being practiced by other communicators. The press would then lend the power of this art to the science of social inquiry thereby creating a new form of journalism. If, as the USA Today experiment suggests, it is not possible to compete with television at the level of form and surpass it at the level of content, then Dewey's dream of interesting the public in the public interest may have been overwhelmed by the logic of mass communication. Interesting the public is one sort of problem, finding and advancing the public interest another; "and never the 'twain shall meet."

A possibility Dewey never considered is that, over time, the means for gaining the audience's attention change the audience, so that certain avenues of communication and forms of learning are no longer available to democracy. If television has altered the way we attend to the world, then it is entirely feasible that there are social problems which

demand levels of attention no citizen can muster. It would be reasonable to argue, for example, that "deficit spending" is an impossible problem to solve democratically because it exists in a time dimension--namely, the future--whose relationship to the present cannot be communicated effectively. Now, there could be no better example of a "public" problem, in Dewey's sense of the term, than large government deficits. And yet it may be that deficits are structured in such a way that there can never be a public for that particular problem-- that is, no body of citizens that understands what makes the problem a public concern. It could further be argued that provoking large deficits has become a new political strategy, a kind of second level or meta-political act, the effect of which is to remove from political discourse an issue which is clearly political. In other words, creating large deficits is a way of acting politically without being held responsible: politics removed from the polity. Traditionally governments have used secrecy and censorship when they did not want to be held accountable for their actions. Basically, they have lied or covered-up. But the example of deficit spending suggests that these methods are outdated. It is now possible to act without public scrutiny simply by creating problems so large and complex and removed from the present that no public can emerge around them. One can take "covert action" out in the

open as long as one is certain that the meaning of the act cannot be communicated effectively.

The possibility of such a strategy gives new significance to the idea of a "democratic" government or politician. A truly democratic politics would have as part of its agenda the effort to restrict the scope of political problems so they do not overwhelm in breadth and depth the means for gaining public attention. One could mount an argument against Ronald Reagan's so-called "Star Wars" program on this basis alone: whatever its merits, the technology is so complex it overwhelms public discourse and is therefore a threat to the principle of democratic control. Of course, it is hard to imagine any politician making such an argument, for the fiction of an informed (and informable) public is deeply rooted in political discourse. The effort to "give democracy a chance" by restricting the scope of problems would no doubt be seen as anti-democratic, as an arrogant and arbitrary effort to decide which problems "the people" can and cannot grasp. Given these difficulties, it is likely that more and more public problems will unfold beyond the reach of public understanding, especially when one considers that the limits of that understanding are shaped by communications media.

This possibility, which for Dewey means the end of the public, does not seem to concern the press. Journalists refer to "the public," "public opinion" and "the public's

right to know" all the time, quite causally, as if there were no question about the relevance of these terms. Clearly, then, the meaning the press assigns to the public is not the same as that which Dewey sought. For if the press shared his understanding of what a public is it would have to conclude that none exists, or that the one that does exist is a fragile, evanescent thing whose standing is always in doubt. Were Dewey's conception to prevail the questions would always be: how much to most people understand about that territory of problems where the common interests are at stake? Do they attend to public problems? If they do, can they trace events to their causes? Can they relate one event to another? Do they show any mastery of the principles of change?

Polling and the informed citizen problem

The press today is remarkably uninterested in these questions, perhaps because it suspects the answers to be so dismal. Occasional articles will appear on how many Americans do not know this fact or that, but there is no systematic coverage of what people know and understand. This lack of interest is all the more significant since the same technologies routinely used to ask people what they believe--the statistical sample and questionnaire--could be employed to discover what people know. In fact, it can be argued that the "science" of polling is more suited to

gauging knowledge than opinion, since opinions formed on the basis of sketchy or absent knowledge are so volatile and unreliable. They may "represent" only that day's semi-conscious urges. Nevertheless, it is public opinion that consistently interests the press, while public knowledge, interest and motivation to learn remain unexamined, except for an occasional expose'.

Since the perfection of sampling technique after World War II it has frequently been shown that citizens have neither the knowledge about nor the interest in political questions that democracy traditionally assumes. In other words, survey evidence has confirmed what Lippmann observed in Public Opinion and the Phantom Public. In 1948 Berelson, Lazarsfeld and McPhee ended their study of opinion formation in the Dewey-Truman election with the following observation, based on polling and interviews with 1,000 residents of Elmira, New York.

The democratic citizen is expected to be well informed about political affairs. He is supposed to know what the issues are, what their history is, what the relevant facts are, what alternatives are proposed, what the party stands for, what the likely consequences are. By such standards the voter falls short. Even when he has the motivation, he finds it difficult to make decisions on the basis of full information when the subject is relatively simple and proximate; how can he do so when it is complex and remote? The citizen is not highly informed on details of the campaign, nor does he avoid a certain misperception of the political situation when it is to his psychological advantage to do so. (308)

Thomas Patterson's 1980 study of voting, though more sophisticated, repeats most of these observations and adds that television news makes the assumption of an informed citizenry even more untenable (153-169). "Casual daily news exposure does not produce informed citizens," Patterson writes. "It results only in a partial awareness of those subjects that repeatedly appear at the top of the news" (174). In an article on "the informed citizen problem in voting research," political scientists Michael Grant and Dwight Davis first quote from Berelson et al. on what the citizen is expected to know, then state that the bulk of the evidence "indicates that the average U.S. citizen cannot come close to meeting such information standards" (133).

The empirical evidence of an uninformed and inactive citizenry threatens to make statistical surveys of public opinion meaningless and plunge the whole enterprise of polling into doubt. A number of strategies have therefore arisen to prevent the skepticism from spreading beyond the research community. One such strategy is to rely on the fact that most people will give an opinion even when they do not know or care about an issue. Thus a kind of "public opinion" can be produced simply by the willingness of citizens to give pollsters answers to most of their questions. A second and slightly more sophisticated strategy is to attempt to give the respondent the knowledge necessary to have a meaningful opinion. For instance, a

pollster may explain what the different tax cut proposals are and what the net effect of each is, then ask which one the respondent favors (Adler 145). The problem of the uninformed citizen is thus "solved" by the intervention of the pollster himself. A third approach is to eliminate from the reporting of "public opinion" those who do not know or care about an issue. A recent New York Times/CBS News poll, for example, examined public support for Reagan's "Star Wars" defense program. At the bottom of a chart summarizing the results was this note: "Those who had no answer or said they did not know are not shown." There was no indication of how many people chose not to answer or claimed not to know, yet the Times felt justified in equating the answers of those who did respond with the views of "the American public" (A10). The same sort of trick is practiced routinely in pre-election polling, where only those people who intend to vote are counted as "the public." By this method apathy as a political reality is defined out of existence. In a study of polling as a manipulative tool Michael Wheeler observes that newspaper polls rarely

reveal whether people who know nothing about the issue were filtered out of the sample. It makes little sense to ask people how they feel about the president's policy on deregulation of natural gas prices if they have not previously considered the matter; a surprisingly high percentage of the population does not think about such questions. (280-81)

A fourth method pollsters use to get around the problem of the uninformed or inert citizen is to identify something called the "attentive public" and distinguish it from the "inattentive public." The opinions of each can then be surveyed and speculation about their relationship can ensue (Adler; Key 544). The genius of this approach is that it takes a problem which undercuts the whole science of polling--that most people do not know enough or care enough to make their opinions meaningful--and transforms it into a methodological issue: how to identify the attentive public, for example. Dewey would consider an "inattentive" public an outrageous contradiction in terms. To the extent that it is inattentive a public simply fails to exist. But for the political scientists and pollsters who practice what C. Wright Mills called "abstracted empiricism," an inattentive public is just another category to be created so that the polling can go on. Creating new categories, reclassifying things, developing new measures-- these are the ways the science of public opinion adjusts itself to the conditions which so concerned Dewey and Lippmann.

Volatility as a technical question

The polling firm of Yankelovich, Skelley and White offers a good example of such an adjustment with a technique called the "Mushiness Index." "Mushiness," according to the

firm, arises from the fact that people are often polled about issues they have not discussed or thought about in any depth. Answers are given, but since they are grounded so thinly they are extremely volatile. This becomes a problem for anyone who wants to rely on the polls. Now, for Dewey the volatility of popular opinion is a problem involving the insubstantiality of our common life. Since a public has not emerged around a shared understanding of the problems affecting common interests, a superficial level of agreement is obtained by other, more mechanical means-- entertainment, marketing, publicity (The Public and its Problems 83-4). Volatility, then, reflects the failure of "the public" as a set of shared concerns to sink deeply into the selves and give a secure basis to opinion. At a deeper level it indicates the failure of communication to create a compelling sense of community across the new dimensions of the Great Society. Yankelovich, Skelley and White are not interested in any interpretation of this sort. They state openly in their report that in developing the "Mushiness Index" their "aim was a refinement or a 'wrinkle' to be added to the current tool kit, rather than a major upheaval" (7). This new "wrinkle" involves adjustments in polling technique designed to measure the solidity of an opinion. The "mushiness" factor is reduced to a mathematical variable which can be thoroughly intergrated into current practice.

The volatility problem is thus taken care of without disturbing the way pollsters go about their business.

To summarize: for Dewey volatility is part of a larger social problem, a defect in our civilization which prevents a democratic public from emerging and trivializes our common life. For Yankelovich, Skelley and White, volatility is a technical problem preventing the instrument of polling from enjoying wider use. In the fifty or so years between The Public and its Problems and the "Mushiness Index" the discourse on public opinion has shifted dramatically. The question of whether or in what form the public exists has disappeared, not because it was in any sense answered but because the technical means for ignoring it presented themselves.⁷

Behind maneuvers like the "Mushiness Index" is an effort to preserve the fiction of a concerned and competent public holding a vast array of opinions on the issues of the day. This effort proceeds despite the knowledge that such a public does not exist. Pollsters know that most people do not know much, care much or learn much about public affairs. But this knowledge threatens to put the pollster out of business, or, worse perhaps, reveal the fact that, in the absence of a solid basis for opinion, polling is not a means for studying public opinion but for creating and manipulating a fiction about it, a de-politicizing force posing as a neutral tool of politics. As Lippmann observed

If the voter cannot grasp the details of the problems of the day because he has not the time, the interest or the knowledge, he will not have a better public opinion because he is asked to express his opinion more often. He will simply be more bewildered, more bored and more ready to follow along. (Phantom Public 36-7)

Most pollsters do double duty. They work as social scientists "reporting" on the public mood and, at the same time, as hired guns helping politicians and businesses fine-tune their appeals. Part of their job is to get the bored and bewildered citizen to "follow along," just as Lippmann said he must do. This presents a difficulty for the polling profession: how to rationalize as "democratic" a technique which capitalizes on the defects of democracy? A naive, pre-Lippmann conception of the democratic citizen is the best solution. A competent, critical and informed public must be assumed to exist, despite all evidence to the contrary. Not only is such a public armed with opinions that must be surveyed, thus giving the pollsters a vital role in the political system, it is also capable of defending itself against deceptive advertising and the phony appeals of pandering politicians. An informed public thus renders the pollster as hired gun harmless, since it is capable of putting the "buyer beware" defense into action in the marketplace of ideas. To make the same point another way: it is not in the interests of professional pollsters to act on their knowledge of widespread ignorance and

indifference. Pollsters have more to gain by pretending that such problems do not exist, first, because the illusion of an informed and competent public gives their surveys of public opinion more meaning, and second, because it makes their work for candidates and corporations more defensible.

The public today: a rhetorical strategy

What polling has become, then, is a way of restoring the solidity of the concept of public opinion after a period of intense scrutiny in the 1920s. It was not only Lippmann and Dewey who were finding fault with inherited assumptions about a democratic public. Sir Roger Angell voiced nearly identical sentiments from England in a pair of books, The Public Mind and The Press and the Organization of Society. In 1924 a Round Table of the National Conference on the Science of Politics found itself unable to agree on any meaning to the words "public opinion" and concluded that it was best to avoid using the term (C. Clark, "The Concept of the Public 311). To say that this advice was ignored would be polite. The literature on public opinion is immense, the polling of the population now a huge industry both inside the academy and out. Much of this literature simply ignores the tradition in which Lippmann and Dewey wrote. The study of public opinion goes on as if doubts about its meaning were never raised.⁸ Polling offered a way of escaping these

doubts, for it was now possible to furnish evidence for the very assumptions that had been called into question. Is it impossible for the citizen to grasp the broad array of issues that affect his life? Look, here are his views on everything from economic policy to foreign affairs. Have problems grown so complex no one can understand them? Here is the New York Times reporting that 56 percent of the public believe the "Star Wars" system will work. Has government gotten so big and bureaucratic that the citizen no longer has a say in running it? Here is a way for officials to keep in constant touch with public desires: polls can make "government by the people" a daily reality. Is the average person immersed in private affairs? Here is⁹ the evidence that he thinks about public questions, too.

This is where social science and journalism achieved their union-- not in the "Thought News" Dewey had hoped for, but in the reconstruction of the "omnicompetent citizen" myth Lippmann had exposed. Social science and journalism come together in the publicity the press gives to public opinion polls, a partnership which helps to suggest that there still is a public "out there" discoursing with a general competence on the issues of the day. In a dramatic moment during his review of Public Opinion, John Dewey, a man whose faith in democracy was remarkably tenacious, paid Walter Lippmann the following compliment. The book, said Dewey,

shivers most of our illusions, and this particular Humpty Dumpty can never be put together again for anyone who reads these chapters with an open mind.
(287)

In a way Dewey was right; but in a way he was wrong. The illusions he thought irretrievable returned not for their intellectual but for their strategic value. Both the press and the pollsters found it convenient to speak of the public as if Lippmann's critique had never been made, despite their knowledge that people do not behave like omniscient citizens. What the public has become, then, is a rhetorical strategy employed for different purposes depending on who is doing the speaking. If the speaker is a pollster "the public" will be said to believe this and reject that as if it has settled and meaningful opinions on every question. In other words, the public will be equated with the results of polls. Meanwhile, among pollsters themselves, all evidence that the public is not informed, does not have secure opinions and is not generally interested will be converted into methodological problems which admit only technical solutions.

The press allows the pollsters to speak through the medium of the news, accepting uncritically the equation between poll results and public opinion--even though journalists know the polls are manipulable--and helping the pollsters out by, for example, defining out of existence those who do not know, do not care or do not intend to

vote. If the speaker is the press, the public is most frequently invoked in the phrase "the public's right to know." The public is that body of persons whose concerns and thirst for knowledge justify the demands of the press for more access and information. It is never the press that wants and deserves to know; it is the public. That is the main use the press has for the public as a rhetorical tool.

Press and government as figure and ground

To show how this tool is used we can examine one of the few statements ever made which could be said to characterize the "position" of the press. Ten major professional organizations, including the wire services, the American Society of Newspaper Editors, the National Association of Broadcasters and the Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press, declared in a public announcement their belief that the press has a right to accompany U.S. troops into battle and observe military operations first hand. The statement was made in response to restrictions on the press during the October 1983 invasion of Grenada. It concluded with the following observation:

Our society remains healthy and free primarily because our public has an independent source of information about its Government. Preservation of this principle is essential to the proper functioning of our constitutional democracy and to our national well being. Without this open flow of information, our system of self-government would not work. (New York Times, "Text of Journalists' Joint Statement" A10).

This kind of talk issues from official bodies so frequently that its assumptions can barely be heard. Let us see if we can articulate them: first, that American society is a system of "self-government" no different in principle from the smallest and purest democracy; second, that this self-governed society is "healthy and free," nothing being seriously wrong with the body politic; and third, that it enjoys this health primarily because the press furnishes the necessary information, the essential characteristic of which is its independence from government. Here we have a clue to what separates a professional press from the tradition of Lippmann and Dewey. For Lippmann and Dewey the important question was the result of communication. Did communication in a democracy achieve what it was assumed to achieve? This focus explains why for both thinkers the problem of journalism and the problem of propaganda were the same. When one is interested in what actually gets communicated, then all communicators are equally important. But for the press professional status lay in distinguishing itself from other communicators. This distinction could not be achieved in the actual communication environment where journalism was practiced. The citizen at whom the news was aimed did not exist. He was also the consumer at whom advertisements were aimed, the reader for whom the newspaper was edited, the

voter at whom propaganda was directed, the idle dreamer whose illusions and urges had become the content of mass culture. More to the point, as a political actor he was likely to assume any of these identities.

Since it was not possible to distinguish journalism from other forms of communication in terms of effect, that is, since people in their roles as citizens did not rely exclusively on news aimed at the citizen--using instead the full repertoire of images lent by their environment--the press looked for another realm in which to achieve its distinction as the upholder of democracy. The communication environment contained too many ambiguities. Originally that other realm was the internal world of the newspaper. The lines between "business" and "editorial," "news" and "advertising," "facts" and "opinions" helped the press establish its professional reputation. These were the founding distinctions which made professional training possible and which created a code of ethics separating journalists from other members of the newspaper staff.

But soon there developed another realm in which the press could actualize its status as the defender of democracy. That was the world of reporters and officials. By becoming a government "watchdog," a permanent critic of elected officials, the press could define and continually reemphasize its status as a public servant. The role of

watchdog offered a way for the press to turn away from the public and yet remain the public's representative, for being a watchdog required no contact with an actual audience, no pandering to mass tastes or to the knowledge level of the average citizen. The solution is ingenious: one dismisses the public entirely, but gives up none of the force in the phrases the "public's right to know," the "public interest," "public accountability," "public information" and so on.

It may sound sacreligious to say so but the press is not really interested in informing the public. If it was it would be very interested in what the public actually knows, what it understands, the reasoning it uses to come to its conclusions, the apathy and ignorance it demonstrates and the political effects of all of these things. The press would be more interested in these questions than in the results of polls, since the results of polls are meaningless outside a grasp of what the population knows and understands. And yet the coverage of public opinion in the press shows a total imbalance, opinion always dominating what little inquiry there is into what people know and learn of public questions.¹⁰ To ask people their "opinion" on the quite technical question of whether a strategic defense system launched from space will work--without knowing or caring how much they understand about the system--is to keep alive what Lippmann called the "intolerable and unworkable

fiction that each of us must acquire a competent opinion about all public affairs." It is to ignore what Dewey said about public opinion, that it is the judgment of those who have formed themselves into a public by achieving a competent grasp of public problems. This condition, he wrote, is "hard to meet." It is something a democracy makes or fails to make of itself. To the press, however, the public is not something made; it is something that exists the way the air and water exist.

Let us be certain of the point we are making. It is hard to see how a series of well documented articles on the ignorance and feeble-mindedness of the average citizen would solve the problem of the public in a modern age. It is hard to see how it would change anything at all, given the structure of the problem. Our interest, however, is in why the press, supposedly dedicated to "informing the public," is so uninterested in what the public knows, and yet so willing to lend coverage to what the public believes and feels. What explains this lack of curiosity about the competence of actual citizens and the willingness to further the myth of the omniscient citizen? The answer we have suggested is that the press creates its professional identity, gets its sense of self, by turning away from the actual public and inhabiting a world where "the issues" are on everyone's lips and politics is the most real and

pressing of problems. It is in this realm that the press acts as a public servant defending the rights of the citizen. How can the press be said to be "serving" the interests of a public in which it has so little genuine interest? By setting itself in opposition to government officials. The press dramatizes its public functions by demanding a level of accountability and candor that politicians are not inclined to accept, thus provoking constant conflict between the press and government out of which the press emerges as the public's defender.

In this conflict the battle cry is the "public's right to know." The absent questions are what the public can, does and wants to know. The press has built an entire self conception on this opposition between journalist and elected official, which it sees as a permanent, inevitable feature of a free society. Because journalists expose the errors and misplays of every Administration, whatever its political stance, because they harass all officials with equal fervor, journalism always appears to be working in "the public interest," rather than for any particular interest. The permanence of the conflict between journalists and officials becomes proof of the profession's sense of public duty. In its own mind, the press is never "on" anyone's side: it is always "against." This "against" is similar to the ground against which any shape becomes intelligible. A very

fundamental principle of meaning is therefore involved. As the criminal creates the figure of the cop, the official who tries to lie, cheat and cover-up creates the figure of the journalist. A secretive government withholding vital information is an essential element in the conception the press has of itself. Here is James Deakin, White House correspondent for the St. Louis Post-Dispatch from 1955 to 1980, on the inevitability of the conflict between the press and the government.

The government wishes its point of view to prevail. It believes its policies are the correct courses of action for the nation. The press reports the government's position. Then it insists on reporting other points of view. The government, except on rare, heartening occasions, does not wish to have its mistakes brought to public attention. The press brings the government's mistakes to public attention. The government, composed as it is of human beings, does not like to be criticized. The press criticizes the government. The government and the press then disagree over whether a mistake was actually a mistake. They disagree over whether criticism was justified. They disagree.

"None of these problems can be resolved," says Deakin. "None of the conflicts can be removed. The fundamental differences between the government and the press are beyond the wit of man to reconcile" (qtd in Thompson 8). What is interesting about this view is that it sees as inevitable not an ideological conflict between a press that is "for the people" and a government that is for "the interests," between liberal reporters and conservative politicians, but a non-political conflict centered around freedom of

information. The government wants to restrict information, the press wants to free it from government control. By emphasizing this conflict above all others, the press puts itself in the best possible light. It is always on the side of the public against a government that is always interested in protecting itself. Remember, according to the press, American society "remains healthy and free primarily because the public has an independent source of information about its government."

Conclusion: the limits of sowing seeds

If information free of government control is the essential ingredient in an informed public, then freeing information from government control is the essential act of journalism. This conception of the press reached its dramatic highpoint in the Watergate scandal, in which the reporters Woodward and Bernstein saved the nation by triumphing over the government's cover-up. The myth of Woodward and Bernstein states that the truth wins out if it can just be released. The reporters become heroes by freeing the truth from government control. Everything else takes care of itself: Nixon is revealed as a crook, justice prevails, normalcy returns, America remains "healthy and free."

Of course there cannot be a Watergate every month. Instead there is the press conference, a ritual in which the

press dramatizes itself as the interrogator of a reluctant government symbolized by the figure of the President. As Grossmann and Kumar observe, the Presidential press conference offers little in the way of information. It is "most important to news organizations because it is an event in which they are important public actors," they write (241). Televising the conflict between a demanding press and a reluctant government shows the journalist in the act of informing the public, the essential characteristic of which is the freeing of truth from official control. Dewey and Lippmann thought that the problem of informing the public had grown far beyond this stage. The environment created by mass communication overwhelmed the issue of censorship, which, after all, is still at the heart of the journalist's sense of self. One could free all the facts in the world and still not be informing the public, for the important question was not what was released into the environment, but what took shape in the beliefs and behavior of the average citizen.

"Seeds are sown," wrote Dewey, "not by being thrown out at random, but by being so distributed as to take root and have a chance of growth." His interest in the conditions of their growth is what makes Dewey the great philosopher of the democratic public.

CONCLUSION

TOWARD AN ECOLOGICAL VIEW OF PRESS AND PUBLIC

Providing information is not all there is to informing the public. It is not the only, or even the primary factor in shaping the relationship between press and public. The present study has attempted to insert a range of other factors between these two key terms. Among them are the size of the world one is to be informed about, the way in which the audience is organized, the competition for attention, the limitations inherent in language and other symbols. When these other factors fail to come to light, those who study and criticize the press are left with a very limited set of questions. Is the press fair? Is it accurate? Is it complete? Are journalists "objective?" These are the issues that dominate when one assumes a public "out there" and a press that is supposed to inform it.¹ There is nothing wrong with these questions, but there is nothing sacred or magical about them either. They have their limits.

To take a simple but frequently overlooked example: most inquiry into the press is concerned quite naturally

with the news. When we ask, "has the press been fair?" we mean "has the news produced by the press been fair?" Again, this is not an illegitimate question, but it is a limited one. For nobody is ever presented with the news alone. Readers of a newspaper encounter pages on which there are advertisements, headlines, photos and news stories. Television viewers are given 22 minutes of news spliced with eight minutes of commercials. "The news" as a corpus of material separate from advertising and other features does not exist in the experience of citizens. In a word, it is an abstraction. The question of fairness or bias in the news therefore has a bias of its own. It is biased toward the experience of the journalist--who produces news, but not advertising--and against the experience of the citizen. Questions about the accuracy, fairness and completeness of news coverage overlook the fact that no one is ever presented with "the news." People encounter a newspaper or a newscast, where the news is embedded in a symbolic structure whose functions may be quite different from that of the press.

If we are interested in what the press does in the world--rather than what it prints or broadcasts--if we want to know about journalism as communication--as opposed to the mere sending of messages--then this other structure must be taken into account. The information the press presents may

be accurate, fair and complete, but it may be more than offset by the distracting power of other features. The world the press constructs for the citizen may be coherent and explicable, but the world implied by the newspaper as a whole, or television as a whole--the world presented through the mass media--may be opaque and nonsensical. The press may speak to people in their public role as citizens, but the aim of mass communication in general may be to reach into private life and merge with the sense of self. The press may indeed be presenting information, in the cybernetic sense of the term. But the media may be working on the principle of redundancy.

The reason for all these "buts" is to stress a point we made in the Introduction to this study: journalism needs to be thought of, not as something journalists do, but as a transaction between producers and consumers, writers and readers, the press and the public. And this transaction must be viewed ecologically. That is, it must set in a particular social context where the world one is to be informed about is symbolized and summed-up, arranged and distorted by a number of communication media. The failure to view journalism as a transaction which takes place in a particular symbolic environment leads to an exclusive and uncritical emphasis on the accuracy, fairness and completeness of the news as information. All other

questions then subside. It is assumed that, if the press will just be accurate, fair and complete, democracy will be restored to the scale of a small town and the omniscient citizen can again direct the course of government. If this sounds like a parody of the prevailing approach to the press, let us hear from two scholars who exemplify that approach. Writing in 1971, Wilbur Schramm and Donald F. Roberts had this to say about press and public:

Because we are so large, because we must make numerous decisions about highly complex and specialized issues, only the media can provide us with much of the information necessary to enable public participation in government. Only the media can insure that this information is complete. Theirs is the responsibility of making sure that the public receives all available information about various issues before those issues are resolved by our elected leaders. Theirs is the responsibility of seeing that information is not censored, not distorted, not incomplete.... To the degree that such responsibility is accepted, the public has the opportunity to consider all the information and to influence the course of their governance. (emphasis in original; 640)

Schramm and Roberts recognize that the world has grown more complex and distant from the daily lives of citizens. But the only conclusion they are able to draw from this fact is that more and better information--indeed, all the information--must be provided to citizens. And it is the duty of the press to provide that information. End of issue. In remarking on the same fact, the increasing complexity of the world that one is to be informed about, sociologists Bensman and Lilienfeld note a problem we

explored earlier in this study: that the conditions which make citizens dependent on the press for information have other consequences as well, many of which are important for an understanding of press and public. They write:

The information talents of the journalist develop in response to needs for substitute sources of information when genuine or direct sources of experience are not available. But this situation, in which the individual is not capable or is presumed to be not capable of evaluating issues and events in terms of direct experience, is precisely the situation which makes possible large-scale fraud, charlatanry, and deceit by misdirection.

As Bensman and Lilienfeld observe, "It is no accident that the beginning of professional propaganda began with the beginnings of professional journalism" (211). The two professions are responses to the same social conditions. They are therefore equally important as factors in the relationship between press and public, a point which Dewey also recognized when he argued that journalism and propaganda are essentially the same problem. This is what we mean by an ecological approach to journalism. The focus is on the conditions linking journalists and their audiences, which are also the conditions linking other communicators to the same audiences. The social conditions which make citizens dependent on the press also make them susceptible to manipulation by other professions, no matter how sound the information the press provides. An ecological approach to the press attempts to include such facts in its view of press and public.

An outstanding example of this sort of approach is contained in the 1947 report of the Commission on Freedom of the Press, chaired by Robert Hutchins. It is not possible to speak about the citizen in the abstract, the Commission noted, for

the citizen is a different man when he has to judge the press alone, and when his judgment is steadied by other social agencies. Free and diverse utterance may result in bewilderment unless he has access--through home, church, school, custom--to interpreting patterns of thought and feeling. There is no such thing as "objectivity" of the press unless the mind of the reader can identify the objects dealt with. (13)

Objectivity, the Commission says, is not a statement about journalism or the journalist, but a relation, a state of affairs, that may or may not exist among the press, the mind of the reader and the external world. Institutions other than the press have a role to play in establishing this relation; and if they are unable to do their part the fact that the journalist is "objective" is meaningless. We have conducted a similar argument about information. Properly considered, "informing the public" is not a statement about the press but a relation that is established (or fails to be established) among the press, its audience and the social context in which communication is taking place. More than the free flow of information is involved. Here we can review the range of other factors that bear on the relationship between press and public, the sorts of

questions an ecological approach to press and public would take up. We have discussed five, each of which is summarized and discussed below.

1. The size and scale of the world the public is to be informed about.

The Greeks thought that there was a natural limit to the size of a democratic state. In his Politics Aristotle says, "A state when composed of too few members is a state without self-sufficiency (and the state, by its definition, is a self-sufficient society). A state composed of too many will indeed be self-sufficient in the matter of material necessities (as un uncivilized people may equally be); but it will not be a true state, for the simple reason that it can hardly have a true constitution. Who can be the general of a mass so excessively large? And who can give it orders, unless he has Stentor's voice?" (VII. iv, Sec. 11 in Barker 292) Here is where the problem of press and public begins, for the press appears to offer "the voice of a Stentor" to government and citizen alike and thus to remove any inherent limit on the size of a democracy. This is one of the reasons freedom of the press is enshrined in the American constitution in the eighteenth century. As the press grows and absorbs new communication technologies it appears to allow constitutional government to be extended over

increasingly longer distances, until in the mid-nineteenth century a "universal town meeting" is said to be possible.

But a hidden complication develops. At the same time that the press is expanding its power to bridge distance, the distances the press must bridge are themselves expanding. An important paradox of communication is involved here. Improvements in communication also make communication more difficult because they ensure that there will be more to communicate about. The marginal gain in access may be more than offset by the geometric increase in the material one needs access to. The printing press, for example, brings more knowledge within the grasp of the reader. In that sense it encourages an "informed public." But print also creates an explosion of knowledge which almost guarantees that the modern reader will be less informed in relation to the total body of knowledge available. Even as it offers citizens a new and powerful source of information the printing press creates an "uninformed public" on a scale unimaginable before print.

Jack Goode and Ian Watt make this point in their essay on "The Consequences of Literacy." The "unlimited proliferation" of knowledge which accompanies widespread literacy "means that the proportion of the whole which any one individual knows must be infinitesimal in comparison with what obtains in an oral culture," they write. A

literate culture thus "prevents the individual from participating fully in the total cultural tradition to anything like the extent possible in non-literate society" (57). What Goode and Watt suggest is that first and only "informed public" is an oral culture, where the sole source of information is speech and ritual and where forgetting is a social act in which everyone shares equally. Writing introduces the possibility of being uninformed, not only by creating new social divisions between the literate and non-literate, but also by expanding the amount of information so drastically that no one can comprehend it all. The printing press magnifies many times over this original "fall from grace" attributable to writing. After writing, there is no hope of creating a society of equally informed citizens. How ironic, then, that literacy has been so closely associated with the dream of democratic citizenship, for it is also one of the social conditions which insures that the dream can never be realized. And so it has been with every improvement in communication: each seems to promise a more educated public; each increase in scale and complexity the the education problem.

It is not only the body of knowledge which expands when communication improves. The world the citizen is to be knowledgeable about is also enlarged. This is a particularly important factor in the relation between press

and public. Improved mail service, for example, allows the merchant to be sent newsletters from the foreign capitals where he may want to do business. But what makes it possible for him to do business in foreign capitals? In part it is the improved mail service. Communication technologies bring news from distant points, but they also make sure that news will be needed since they allow for action to be conducted at a distance. Moreover, there is no guarantee that improvements in news-gathering will keep pace with the increase in the number of points from which news is needed. Nor is there any reason to assume that improvements in information delivery will be accompanied by improvements in the ability to store, manage and interpret information, a point stressed in Chapters Two and Three. These are all reasons why the growth of the press cannot be equated with an "informed public." As the press expands so does the world the press is attempting to "cover." And this relation is not coincidence. The social changes which cause the press to expand also cause the world of the citizen to multiply in scale and complexity.

The best example here is urbanization. The daily newspaper is a child of the city; urbanization is what creates the modern newspaper. But urbanization also creates an environment in which individuals do not share a common world, where their fates are not linked by a common past and

where action in one realm can easily escape the notice of another. Thus, while the popular newspaper is able to reach and inform more citizens than ever, it can only arise in an environment whose size and scale guarantees that the city dweller will be less informed than the resident of a small town. A certain loss of coherence accompanies the growth of the city, which the newspaper, a child of the city, does not make up for.

Jefferson is one of the few advocates of the press who understood this fact. That is why he wanted his countrymen to live in small towns and to organize their government into wards. Many have perceived that the world is becoming a bigger and more complicated place. But the conclusion they have always drawn is that the press must therefore improve its performance in informing us about the world. Jefferson had a different idea: shrink the world, or, if that is not possible, keep it to a manageable size. In some ways the suggestion is utopian, part of Jefferson's idealization of the small agrarian community. But in another sense it is the most practical of ideas. If an "informed public" is truly a value to be upheld--and every defense of democracy suggests that it is--then what needs to be defended is not only the right of the press to furnish the information on which such a public depends, but also the right of the public to a world which is capable of being grasped.

Freedom of information is important, but so is the freedom from an unduly complicated and interrelated public realm.

It would be possible to attribute the success of Ronald Reagan to his recognition of the popular desire for relief from the confused and impenetrable world of public affairs. In this sense Reagan is a democratic politician par excellence. In word if not always in deed he stands for a world which is small in scale and simply ordered, where individuals rather than social forces are responsible for what happens, where religion, family and custom still have a grip on the important problems and can show us the way. Reagan himself denies the necessity for any special expertise in governing. He is known for not getting involved with the details of problems, and his explanations of policy often rely on a kind of folk wisdom drawn from years of campaigning. Some of the programs Reagan has sponsored actually try to put into practice his vision of understandable government. The principle of returning federal programs to states and localities could be interpreted as a Jeffersonian inspiration for creating a better informed public. The call for tax simplification can be seen in the same light. Of course in his defense build-up Reagan has followed exactly the opposite course, favoring technologies (such as the "Star Wars" system) which not even the experts appear to understand.

But whether or not Reagan has created a more understandable government is not the point. What we are trying to illustrate is one of the ways in which "informing the public" involves more than providing information. It also includes the size and complexity of the world one is to be informed about. It would be interesting indeed if a politician appeared in the land with this as a goal: a government the average citizen can grasp. Such a campaign might raise a whole series of issues that have never been treated as political problems. For example, one might object to nuclear power on the grounds that, whether it is safe or not, it is impossible for the average citizen to understand how it works. Nuclear technology could be seen as inherently "undemocratic" no matter what its merits. A campaign for an understandable world might also create political issues out of the forms of discourse used in politics. Campaign advertising on television could be seen as a political problem, a form of discourse which is so limited that it cannot help but muddle the citizen's understanding of problems. A ban on such ads could be one plank in a platform for an understandable world. The admittedly utopian character of such a platform might also raise important questions about the limits of democracy as a way of life. It might become clear, for example, that a society cannot dedicate itself to technological progress and

also expect ordinary citizens to understand its problems. The notion of "appropriate" (or understandable) technology might then obtain new life as part of the democratic dream, alongside a free press, public education and economic opportunity.

Along with Jefferson, John Dewey stands out as one of the few thinkers concerned about the size and complexity of the world the public was to be informed about. This led him to observations the American press is incapable of making. For example, the press equates public affairs with politics, a leap of logic Dewey would never make. Political problems are not the public's problems, he would say, until they are understood as public by the people affected. Similarly, political opinion is not public opinion unless it is based on an understanding of what makes the question a public question. A kind of politics can be conducted in the absence of these conditions, Dewey recognized. There can be issues and parties, platforms and programs, despite the functional derangement of politics from public understanding. When this happens politics is not a dramatization of the problems facing the community, but a circus of distractions, a symptom of a diseased polity. The main reason for paying attention to politics today, Dewey thought, "is that politics so well exemplify the existing social confusion and its causes" (Individualism Old and New 114).

This is an idea which would never occur to the press. That politics is not the arena in which the society's problems are addressed but a showcase for the inability of society to organize itself democratically; that the world of politics is a mirror, not of American life, but of the confusion from which Americans suffer as a political people; that the political realm is effectively dysfunctional, of interest not as a reflection but as a distortion of reality-- these possibilities cannot be assimilated by a press which equates public affairs with government policy and election campaigns. But they might arise as legitimate issues if the size and scale of the world one is to be informed about were inserted as factors in the relationship between press and public. It might then become clear that much of what passes for politics in America--"leadership" as a campaign issue, for example--is not based on the perception of a problem facing the commonwealth, but a sign of the inability of the political realm to make clear just what the public's problems are.

Recall that there two meanings to the term "public" in Dewey's thought. One is the body of citizens in a democratic state. The other is the realm of problems in which those citizens have an interest. Citizens do not form a public, Dewey argued, until they collectively understand the problems which concern them as citizens. What is so

useful about this formulation is that it allows for a more complex view of change, especially of the changes brought by communication media. Improvements in the speed and reach of communication technologies have traditionally been applied to one "public" but not the other. They have been seen as new and more powerful links between the citizen and the world. Debate has centered around the quality of the communication made possible by new technologies-- in the case of the press, around the accuracy, fairness and completeness of the news. But there is a whole other dimension to the problem of communication and an informed public: the effect of communication changes on the realm of problems in which the citizen has a legitimate interest.

Dewey's argument was that modern technologies were making more and more issues "public" issues by involving every local unit in national structures of commerce and government which linked every citizen in a web of complicated inter-relationships. The same changes which brought news from all over the world to the newspaper office and a copy of the newspaper to every home were also responsible for a geometric increase in the realm of public problems. The modern business corporation, for example, raised new sorts of public problems by controlling production and distribution across state and local lines. Inability to understand this new scale had loosened the

average citizen's grip on the world. And yet the modern business corporation was made possible, in part, by the printing press, railroad, telegraph and telephone-- the very improvements which, in another context, seemed to offer the citizen a firmer grasp on the world. An ecological approach to the history of communication would have to take this sort of complication into account. With every improvement in the delivery of information comes a new level of difficulty for citizens seeking to understand their world. No doubt this is one reason why we saw often seem to have more information and yet be less informed.

2. The character of the social bond among members of the audience.

The second factor that needs to be placed between press and public is the type of social arrangements prevailing among members of the audience. We saw in the second chapter, for example, that an item of gossip has a different function when it is whispered in a small town and when it is published in a metropolitan newspaper. Gossip is a form of news in both cases; but where it functions as information in a small town, supplementing more public forms of talk, in a city newspaper it is an act of story-telling, a small drama in which the reader can participate as a spectator. What news does for people varies depending on how the people are

grouped as a social unit. Thus, the "public" addressed by the newsletter of a thriving labor union is likely to be interested in the problems which unite its members. It is likely to see them in political terms, and to be capable of receiving information about them. The editor of a journal addressing such a public should not have to concern himself with getting the attention of readers because the world the readers share does that job for him. Everyone knows what the important issues are: pay scales, working conditions, benefits. A union newspaper is also unlikely to contain advertising, since the need for news is obvious and common enough to the people involved that they are willing to support the publication more directly through union dues. If there is no advertising there is no need to continually maximize circulation, which in turn means that news coverage will not have to compete with attention-getting devices like gossip and crime.

All these features arise from the way the audience is organized as a group, or, to rephrase the idea slightly, from the common activity members of the audience share. The less compelling that common activity, the more work the journalist has to do just to hold the audience together. When there is nothing substantial holding the audience together, anything and everything can become "news" if it succeeds in gaining the attention of a sufficiently large

circle of readers. This is the setting in which most local TV newscasts take place. Another name for this development is sensationalism. Sensationalism is not a quality inherent in certain publishers or newspapers; nor is it a reflection of the audience's "true" desires. It arises from the ability to link through media of communication people who would not otherwise perceive themselves as a group. Sensationalism is what happens when communication outruns the sense of community.

With his skeptical view of the telegraph Thoreau showed an advanced understanding of the roots of sensationalism. Texas and Maine can now communicate, he noted; but what if they have nothing to say to one another? Thoreau suggested the answer when he wrote, "We are eager to tunnel under the Atlantic and bring the old world some weeks nearer the new; but perchance the first news that will leak through into the broad, flapping American ear is that princess Adelaide has the whooping cough" (52). Gossip about the health of a princess is likely to characterize trans-Atlantic communication because, as Thoreau suggested, there was not necessarily a trans-Atlantic community to accompany the cable. Or at least such a community had not yet been brought to life. Here is where Dewey's insistence that the public understand its problems becomes so important. The existence of common concerns--let us say between England and

America--may be the theoretical basis for a trans-Atlantic community. In this sense a "public" linking the peoples of the two nations would be possible; and informing such a public could become the function of a press equipped with a trans-Atlantic cable. But if the common concerns are not recognized and understood as such by the people involved, then this Anglo-American community will not function as the basis for the journalism which links one continent to another. Instead the news from England will be Adelaide's whooping cough, or, in our own time, the wardrobe of Princess Di.

Now, it is possible for the press to go ahead and publish the news which a trans-Atlantic public would require to "stay informed" if it existed. Indeed, the New York Times publishes news of this sort all the time, from almost every foreign capital in the world. Whatever the character of this news, the Times cannot be said to be "informing the public" if there is no understanding of why the news from foreign capitals makes a difference to Americans in the first place. Without a common recognition of the problems linking governments and people all over the world, foreign news does not function as information, even if it is presented that way by the press. More is involved here than the common complaint that the news arrives without a "context" for understanding it. It is not simply a

disfunctional, events having surpassed it. In a sense there is no public on the issue of nuclear war; its functions have been wiped out by the permanence and inevitability of Mutually Assured Destruction.

As an activity journalism arises when the affairs of people are extended across space. But it is also deeply bound by conceptions of time. Without the belief that events unfolding in the present make a difference for the future there can be no journalism in any significant sense. The National Enquirer is a good indication of what journalism becomes when the sense of time which supports the journalistic enterprise degenerates. In the Enquirer it is "the miraculous" which prevails over any linear notion of progress. Miracle drugs and diets, astounding scientific discoveries which disprove all previous knowledge, calamities and plagues, unspeakable crimes committed for no apparent reason, invasions from outer space, and, above all, life after death-- all are incompatible with the linear progression of history out of the past and into the future. The world erupts out of nowhere and goes nowhere. Life either ends in a bang or goes on forever. By contrast consider information journalism in its purest form: the sports pages. Last night's baseball scores are fit into today's league standings; tonight's games are previewed. The pennant race stretches out of the past and into the

future through a report on the present state of affairs.

One of the oddities of journalism is that the press cannot itself create the sense of time which makes possible its own information functions. In fact, it has had much to do with the destruction of that sense. The feeling of things spinning out of control, of events as eruptions from nowhere, of crisis as a permanent condition-- these have all been nourished by the press, and not only by the likes of the National Enquirer. Television news may be inherently biased against the sense of time on which the whole concept of news depends. Although it is surely capable of relaying the latest word about events--and in that sense can perform journalistically--the larger question is whether television can reproduce in its audience the belief that events progress out of the past and into the future, and that the way in which they do progress matters. Indeed, the same question can be raised about the newspaper as a form. It is possible that the newspaper is by nature a discontinuous medium, which is something that Marshall McLuhan, for one, admired about the daily press (Understanding Media 207).

Here is another way in which "informing the public" is a very limited description of what the press does. Over time the press may be un-forming the public by destroying the mental conditions which make "informing the public" possible. The Hutchins Commission recognized this possibility in its report.

Whether at any time and place the psychological conditions exist under which a free press has social significance is always a question of fact, not of theory. These mental conditions may be lost. They may also be created. The press is always one of the chief agents in destroying or in building the bases of its own significance. (13)

But not the only agent. The historical forces which group people together in new ways and allow for different types of sociability are also a primary factor in the relation between press and public. The rise of the city, the political party, the nation as social structures, the creation of national communities of interest surrounding such topics as sports and business, the assembling of a permanent nightly audience for television-- these new forms of sociability (some of which are decidedly un-social) imply different functions for journalism and different relationships between press and public. In each case, it is the common activity members of the group share (or fail to share) which accounts for the forms of journalism that develop. In general, the greater and more compelling the common activity, the more the press serves information functions aimed at public life. The more insubstantial the common life of the group, the more journalism tends toward the production of attention and the privatizing of public discourse. In all cases, there is one fact which needs to be kept in mind: improvements in communication do not necessarily create bigger or better communities.

3. Structural characteristics of the mass media.

Journalism does not stand alone as a social institution. It is contained within a larger structure, the mass media, which limits and shapes the relationship the press can establish with its public. There are two important structural features of mass communication which bear on the themes of this study. The first is the privatizing effects of mass communication; the second is the competition for attention which the mass media sponsor.

James Carey is one of the few communication scholars still interested in the concept of the public. Fully aware of the questions left unanswered in the work of Lippmann and Dewey, Carey has ventured to update the problem of the public by adding the perspectives of Harold Innis. For Carey the public is now a myth. As a "sphere of rational discourse" it does not exist; its place has been taken by the public opinion poll which is nothing more than a "statistical artifact," a "concatenation of individual judgments" bearing no resemblance to an active democratic public. One of the forces producing what Carey calls "the eclipse of the public" is the professionalization of the press, which was discussed in Chapter Six. Another is a feature of mass communication examined in Chapter Four, what we called "public transmission, private reception." Carey writes:

Our system of communication is not addressed at the public but at private individuals. We have evolved a radical form of mobilized privacy: the individual hooked into long lines of communication from remote sources. This transformation involved the displacement of the reading public--a group who spoke to one another about the news in rational and critical ways--into a reading and listening audience. It involved the deverbalization of public space into a zone of privacy and intimacy. Whether one examines the technology of communication, transportation, housing, power, or whatever, the general story is told: a service is piped into the private zone of the isolated individual from a centralized source. ("A Plea for the University Tradition" 854)

The best example of the dynamic described by Carey is the television audience, each member of which is sitting in a private home experiencing the news as a kind of invasion of personal life. That some may welcome the invasion (that is, enjoy the news) does not change the fact that the news is aimed at private individuals occupying a private zone of experience, each tempted to descend into private flights of fancy by the commercials and entertainments. Imagine how different the news would be as a communication ritual if it were broadcast in public areas, where individuals gathered each evening to learn of their common fate. To be "public" in character journalism must not only be about public affairs; it must communicate publicly, which is a far more difficult question. The most public form of communication is obviously speech, the original method of "informing the public" and the only method possible according to the Greeks. In a sense, then, journalism has been biased

against the public realm from the beginning. Why? Because it has always been experienced through reading, an oddly private act. The very possibility of an "informed public," a group of citizens actively discoursing about the news of the day, is undermined by the fact that each citizen receives the news from the private act of reading, an encounter with the text whose outstanding feature is that it can be structured and re-structured according to the desires of the individual reader. The idea that many people will read the same thing and come away with a common understanding of problems actually cuts against the dynamics of textual interpretation, which allow for many versions of the same "story" to arise from the text.

These contradictions between the reading of newspapers and a hearing, speaking public have never been fully acknowledged in discussions of press and public. The pressure has been in the opposite direction: toward equating the community of readers with a speech community. The First Amendment, in guaranteeing freedom of speech and the press in the same breadth, suggests that the two are equally public, equally vital to the health of a democracy. The press is seen as sponsoring the same kind of public life as speech, but with the added advantage of print's properties as a medium: durability, portability, etc. It is assumed that more people and more topics can now be included in the

speech community because the boundaries of that community have been extended by the press. The assumption that print was an extension--rather than a reversal--of speech eased the way for an equally uncritical equation between print and television two centuries later. The fact that most people now get their news from television has not led to a wholesale rethinking of the concepts of public opinion and "informing the public." Why should it? If democratic theory could gloss over the contradictions between a hearing public and a reading public, it can certainly make allowances for television, which, as Walter Ong suggests, has a certain "oral" character to it anyway (136-7).

The somewhat contradictory dream of a "community of readers" is embodied also in the myth of collegiality as spoken on college campuses. The university is assumed to be a place where scholars who descend into a private life of the mind through print can nonetheless recover the close communal world of speech and share a universe of discourse with each other. Among the difficulties the university has in realizing this vision is the rapid accumulation of knowledge, which, of course, is one of outstanding features of print civilization. If scholars find it difficult to "keep up" in their own specialist worlds, how can they find the time to do the common reading without which collegiality cannot exist? No wonder, then, that parking problems and

enrollment figures are the most frequent topics at faculty meetings. The university, the citadel of print culture, must struggle to maintain itself as a speech community because it is actually organized against that community's principles.

The point is relevant to the present study because an "informed public" and a "community of scholars" embody the same faint hope: that by isolating themselves from the community through the encounter with the printed page, people will in fact realize a higher form of community, one based on the wider world of knowledge print makes available to the reader. If the idea of a public informed by the press is to be taken seriously, then the discussion must not only include the information the press provides but the "public-ness" of the medium providing it. Such a perspective would reveal contradictions in the idea of an informed public which are obscured by an uncritical emphasis on information alone. Not only the printing press, but the entire communication system can be evaluated for the way in which it encourages or undermines public life. As should be clear by now, this evaluation must focus on the formal characteristics of communication media. For a medium can offer a very "public" content and yet be privatizing a privatizing force as a form.

A second structural characteristic of mass communication which needs to be taken into account is what we have called the competition for attention. Here is where the economic basis of the mass media enters the relationship between press and public. Briefly summarized, the argument is this: At a certain point in its development a capitalist economy solves the problem of production and turns its efforts to consumption. It begins to produce consumers. The American economy reached this point in the decades around the turn of the century. To accomplish the goal of producing consumers the economy must have access to the hearts and minds of the people who are expected to consume more and more. The press becomes one the chief means for gaining that access. The press offers business a product: the attention of the consumer. To create the product the press must discover, first through trial and error, later by inductive research, the features which persuade large numbers of people to pick up the newspaper. This search is spurred on by the competition among newspapers for the advertising dollar. The result is a new climate for communication, in which much of the content of communication is concerned with securing the conditions under which communication can take place.

In Chapter Six we interpreted these events as a shift in the character of public life. Where attention had once

been granted, in the new environment created by the mass communication attention was something that had to be gained. The struggle to gain attention changes the terms on which communication can take place, not only for those competing to sell papers and products, but for all communicators. Journalists who did not compete in the hysterical race to boost circulations were still affected, as communicators, by the new imperative to gain the attention of an easily distracted consumer. The question then arises whether it is possible to "inform the public" when entire industries are at work to distract and amuse the people who are supposed to be informed.

John Dewey attempted to come to grips with this problem by suggesting that journalists must compete with the attention-producing industry in order to maintain the public character of the public realm. Discoveries in the art of arresting attention must be put to good use by public-minded journalists rather than exploited for private gain, Dewey thought. Walter Lippmann was more interested in a possibility Dewey had overlooked: that audience-centered communication, symbolized by the stereotype, was incompatible with the goal of "informing the public." Opposite principles were involved, said Lippmann. The stereotype began with the private beliefs of the individual and reinterpreted the world in those terms, while the

information vital to public affairs began with events in the world and aimed itself at the belief structure of private individuals, hoping to adjust that structure to more accurately reflect reality. Extraordinary levels of time, effort and intelligence were needed to continually revise one's opinions in light of new information, Lippmann observed; and there was no evidence to suggest that most people approached the news in this sober and scientific fashion. They were more likely to take the path of least resistance and to believe what the limited horizon of their experience led them to believe, especially since the advertiser, propagandist and politician were encouraging just such a path. This path of least resistance is what the production of attention was all about.

What Lippmann's argument suggests is another sense in which mass communication sponsors the privatization of the public realm. The competition for attention forces communicators to work from belief toward reality, from private toward public life, rather than the reverse. The dream of an informed public has always assumed that communication will bring the individual out from the darkness of private life into a public world. But a commercialized mass media attempts an opposite course: to refashion the world in the shape of the individual's beliefs and desires. To re-state the point in Freudian terms: the

notion of an informed public suggests that communication works on the reality principle; but the structure of the mass media forces communication to work on the pleasure principle. (Which, of course, does not mean that pleasure is actually delivered.) So, while the press may be saying, as Walter Cronkite did, "And that's the way it is," the rest of the communication environment is offering what Burger King offered, "Have it your way." Adjusting desires to a world which does not always fulfill them is what Freud called the reality principle and it is the principal principle of journalism. But it may have nothing to do with reaching a mass audience.

Criticism of the commercial, advertising-based structure of the press has historically been misplaced. It tends to focus either on the direct manipulation of the news by the advertiser--which is a rare and unnecessary act--or on the pressures to "sell papers" and "keep the ratings up," neither of which ought to be seen as antithetical to the goals of journalism. A truly public press would have to be concerned with selling papers and succeeding in the ratings, for it would want to be reaching the citizens in whose name it toils. The real problem with the commercial structure of journalism is that it compromises what can only be called the "objectivity" of the press. By this we mean not the ideology of journalists or the alleged neutrality of the

news, but the separation between journalism as a report of the world and the citizen as a subject in it. The most insidious pressure a commercialized press exerts is on the boundary between subject and object, inner and outer world, private life and public events. Mass communication attacks this boundary in order to sell goods, and as it does so it changes the terms on which all communication takes place. The reality principle loses its power and with it go the classical functions of the press: "to orient man and society in an actual world," as Robert Park put it.

4. The nature of language and symbols.

For years Time and Newsweek have used almost identical cover photos in ads designed to promote their magazines. It is a picture taken from space in which the earth appears as a little blue ball in a black sky. This image dramatizes the central conceit of journalism: that it can deliver the world, complete and intact, from a point outside the world. Naturally a photograph is used to express this idea, for as Roland Barthes has written, photography is a "message without a code," a way of representing the world which seems to escape the limitations of language ("The Photographic Message" 17). But in fact there is no escape. Even with photography there is the position of the camera, the choice of what to shoot, the "way of seeing" which a culture

works into its photographs, all of which make photography a kind of symbol system, or a "language" in the broader sense of the term. Every system of symbols is by necessity a reduction of what is given to the senses.

Attention must be called to this very elemental fact of human experience because it is so often denied by the myths surrounding such concepts as "information" and "objectivity"-- indeed, by the very notion of "the news." The famous motto "All the News That's Fit to Print" started out as a moral message meant to emphasize the uprightness of the Times in comparison to other, sleazier papers. The important word was "fit." But the emphasis has since shifted to the word "all," as if it were not only possible, but desirable to gather and print "all the news." An apparently innocent phrase like, "Here's what's happening," which might be heard on any local newscast around America, expresses the same conceit: that journalism is not a selected sample of events but the events themselves. How odd (and accurate) it would be if, at the top of the show, an announcer said, "Good evening. Here's one version of what's happening."

Like all systems of representation, the news transforms the world into a set of symbols which are smaller in number and poorer in diversity than the events to which they refer. That is what Barthes means by a "code." A code limits and

shapes the messages that can be communicated in ways that have nothing to do with the "bias" or neutrality of the communicator as an individual. In the case of the news it has been pointed out many times that news collects at certain points and in certain forms which have become part of the journalistic routine. Violence, for example, has always been a collection point for the news, as a succession of aggrieved social groups has discovered. When conditions explode into violence they become "newsworthy," not because they are more real--in the case of terrorism they are actually less real--but because they are now expressed in a symbolic form which can easily be translated into news. A press release is a very simple example of this same translation process. The art of writing a press release is to give the event that is to be publicized the symbolic form of a news story.

In considering, then, whether or under what conditions the press "informs the public," it is not enough to ask about the completeness, accuracy and fairness of "the news." For all systems of representation, including the news, are by necessity incomplete, inaccurate and, in a way, unfair, as any poet who has tried to put love into words knows. So we must also consider the limitations of news as a symbol system. Lippmann was extremely aware of such limits. The news is biased toward the observable event, he noted. But

great portions of the truth about a culture are not observable as events. They exist as conditions, constants, or slow creeping changes which do not disturb the surface. Others have noted that the news as a symbol system is biased toward the statements of official authorities. This bias is important because there is no guarantee that the authorities will say anything of interest or tell the truth. There are other limitations: The way in which the world is divided up by the news is not the only way to divide up the world. The business pages, for example, an accepted division of the world practiced by every metropolitan newspaper in the country, address the world of business from the point of view of a person in business. But business touches lives in many forms other than this. As consumers, as parents, as teachers and students, as artists, as political actors people may meet up with business in ways the business pages do not speak to. The business section implicitly says, "Here's what's happening in business" but what it actually offers is "what's happening in business for people who are in business and want to improve their position," which, after all, is only one way of representing "what's happening" in business and a very limited one at that.

One of the remarkable things about the American press which goes almost unnoticed by scholars and critics is the degree of unanimity which exists about how to divide up the

world into news. Put 100 reporters in a room and hold a press conference or a debate and there will be very little disagreement about what was newsworthy in the event.² Take 100 papers from 100 cities and there will be almost no difference in the division of the paper into sections: general news, sports, business, lifestyles. In fact, these papers will show very few differences of any kind. Perhaps this unanimity is evidence of a solid grip on the world. The conventions of journalism may constitute a proven method for representing the day's events which is widely adopted because it works so well. But consider another possibility: that they are the sort of conventions George Orwell was talking about when he referred to the "Geneva Conventions of the mind"-- that is to say, agreed upon ways of thinking which hold their place simply because they make life easier for those who rely on them. If that is the case, then "informing the public" may require a constant experiment with the conventions of journalism. Perhaps we need a press which emerges with 100 hundred different versions of "the news" when it attends a press conference. Or perhaps we need a press which, instead of attending press conferences at all, is at 100 different places looking for news.

The point of these suggestions is that between press and public is a symbol system, the news, which, like any symbol system, limits and shapes what can be communicated.

As the world changes, it may be necessary for this symbol system to change. But even a sensitive and shifting set of conventions will run up against a basic fact of all languages: the necessity (and danger) of reduction. Presenting "all the news" is therefore an impossible goal, and the press that avows it can only be an impossible press.

5. The professional attitude.

Points we have made about communication could also be made about transportation. We could say, for example, that the automobile appears to promise an increase in travel power. And on one level it does: we can go more places. But when a culture adopts the automobile as its basic unit of transportation there is also a loss in travel power. One must suddenly travel greater distances to obtain the same things which were once obtainable by walking. And since total travel increases the net gain for the individual may be negligible, a fact best typified by the urban traffic jam. All those commuters simmering in their individual cars do not seem to be experiencing a gain in personal mobility. If we are interested in the automobile as a social instrument we would have to take these complications into account. We cannot just say, "people buy cars because they need to go places" for in an important sense they need to go places because they buy cars. In tangling with this sort of

fact we are likely to come across another, equally interesting fact: that there is a myth, a romance about the automobile which accounts for much of its effect. Regardless of what it does for people, people think of the automobile in a certain way, and they are encouraged to do so by their culture. Such a myth must also be a part of our inquiry, for in a way it is just as "real" as the traffic jam and partly responsible for it.

So it is with press and public. Part of our inquiry must involve the myth or romance that surrounds these terms. The trick, of course, is to reveal such myths without participating in them, and, at the same time, to avoid that more subtle myth which sees scholarship as a simple act of debunking. The most important set of myths we have examined is what we have called the "professional attitude" in journalism, which can be described as a certain view of press and public. In this view, it is the performance of the journalist in presenting information accurately, fairly and completely which determines whether or not the press "informs the public." The professional attitude then prescribes a set of standards for the performance of the journalist which, if upheld, will make certain that "the press informs the public." Criticism, scholarship and the training of journalists in turn concern themselves with the problem of meeting and refining these standards, especially

those which concern objectivity.

The most important finding of this study is that the professional attitude is a very limited view of press and public. It assumes too many things and ignores others completely. "Informing the public" involves much more than presenting information accurately, fairly and completely, we have said. It involves the whole problem of what a public is, and whether it is possible to establish a public in a modern environment. It involves the difficult question of what exactly information is, and the social conditions which call its functions into being. It involves all the other forms of communication which surround the press, including, of course, the new form of television. It involves the competition for attention which changes the terms on which the press can communicate. It involves the type of social structure shared by the people who are to form the public. It involves the nature of news as a symbol system. Finally--and here is where the myth comes in--"informing the public" involves the beliefs and conventions which prevent students of the press and the press itself from realizing these other factors.

What overall conclusions, then, can be drawn from this study? They have just been named. "Insert the competition for attention" is a conclusion. "Include the conditions which make information possible" is also a conclusion.

"Consider the nature of news as a symbol system" is a conclusion as well. Granted, these conclusions do not conclude very much. Their only value lies in what they may start: a re-thinking of press and public.

Toward that end let us conclude with a negative, a warning about a way of thinking which this study has sought to overcome. For any press anywhere, making things public does not a public make.